# WHEN WE FORGET THE ARTIFICIAL IN AI: PSYCHOTHERAPY IS NOT A CODE

Maria Jose Viveros Riquelme

Professor Anna Devarakonda

ITAI 2372

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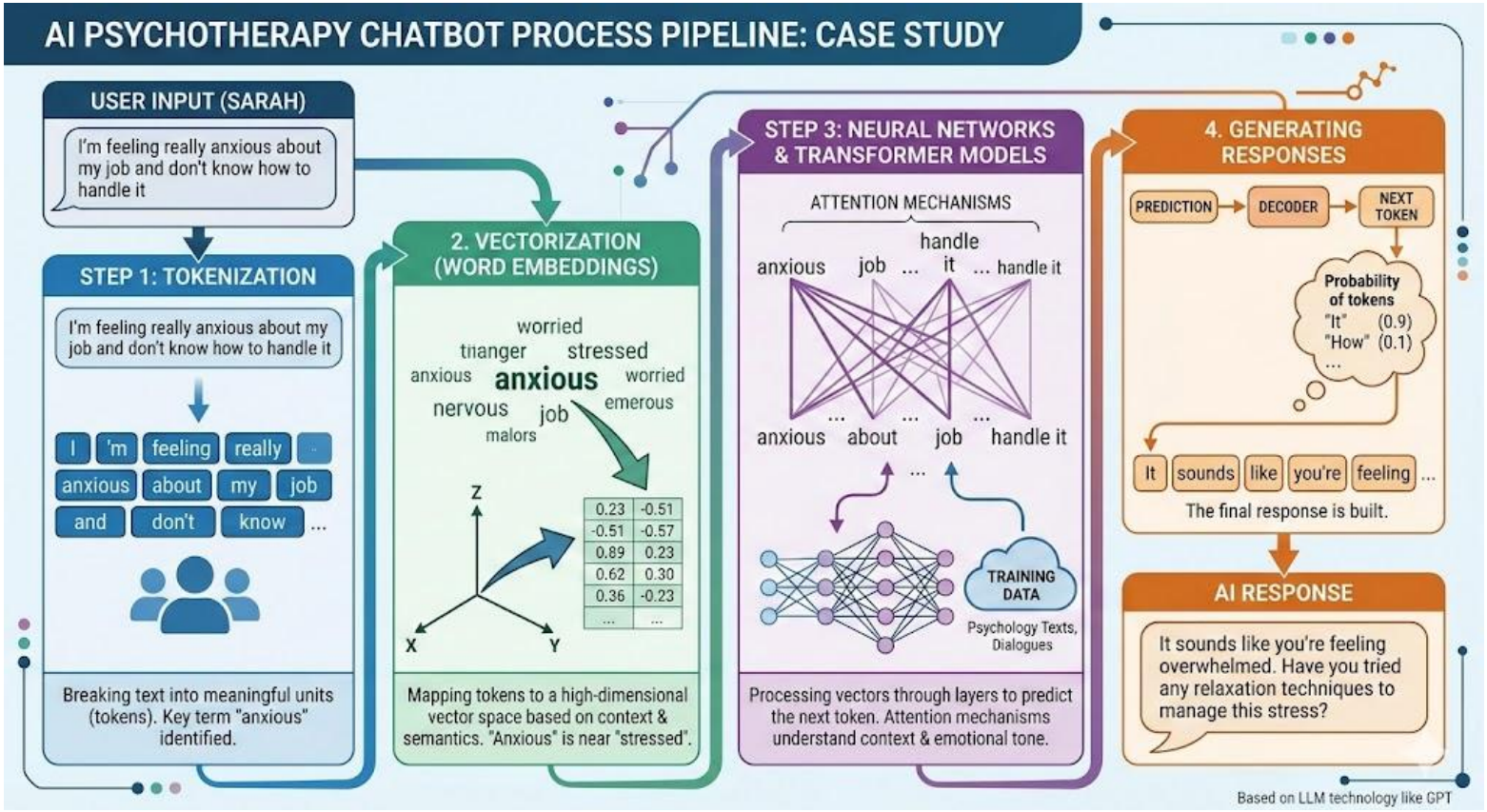
# When We Forget the Artificial in AI Psychotherapy Is Not a Code

- AI has entered mental health under a narrative of innovation, accessibility, and democratization of care.
- Psychotherapy chatbots are presented as scalable solutions to therapist shortages, stigma, cost barriers, and long waiting lists.
- However, psychotherapy is not merely structured dialogue. It is a relational, ethical, and human practice.

# Case Study: Woebot and AI Therapy

- Woebot delivers CBT-based interventions through automated conversation.
- LLM-based systems now generate increasingly fluent therapeutic dialogue.
- While benefits are measurable, philosophical and clinical concerns remain.

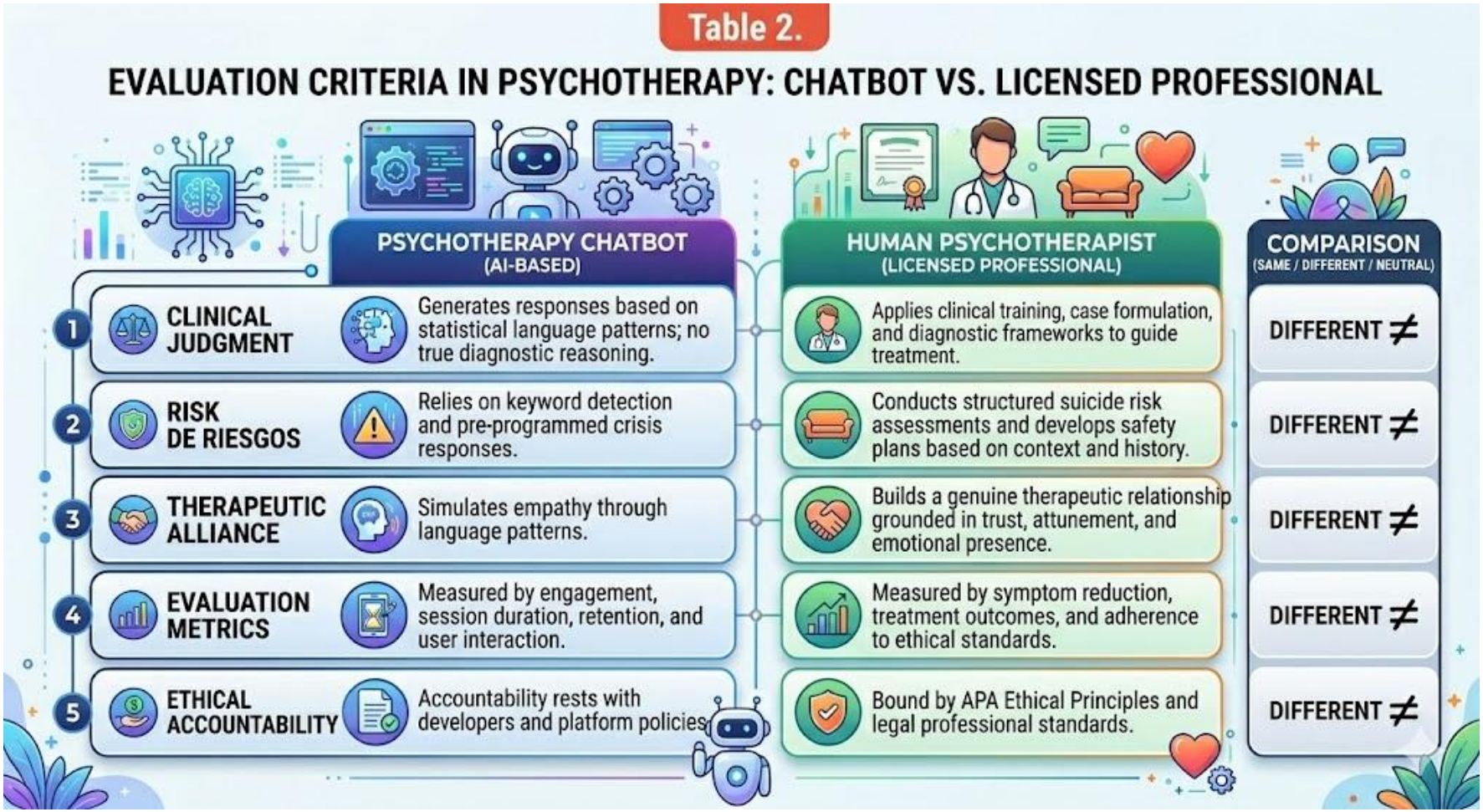
# Technology Behind AI Psychotherapy



# Core Limitation: No Clinical Reasoning

- AI does not internalize clinical reasoning.
- Licensed therapists use training, supervision, and ethical frameworks.
- AI relies only on statistical correlations.
- Prediction is not equivalent to clinical judgment.

# Evaluation Differences



# Benefits of AI Psychotherapy Chatbots

- Immediate access and 24/7 availability.
- Reduced stigma through anonymity.
- Scalable psychoeducational tools such as breathing exercises and CBT prompts.
- Can function as complementary tools.

# Ethical Implications

- Informed consent may be unclear.
- Users may overestimate AI capability.
- Sensitive mental health data requires strict privacy protections.
- Transparency and governance are essential.

# Societal Impact

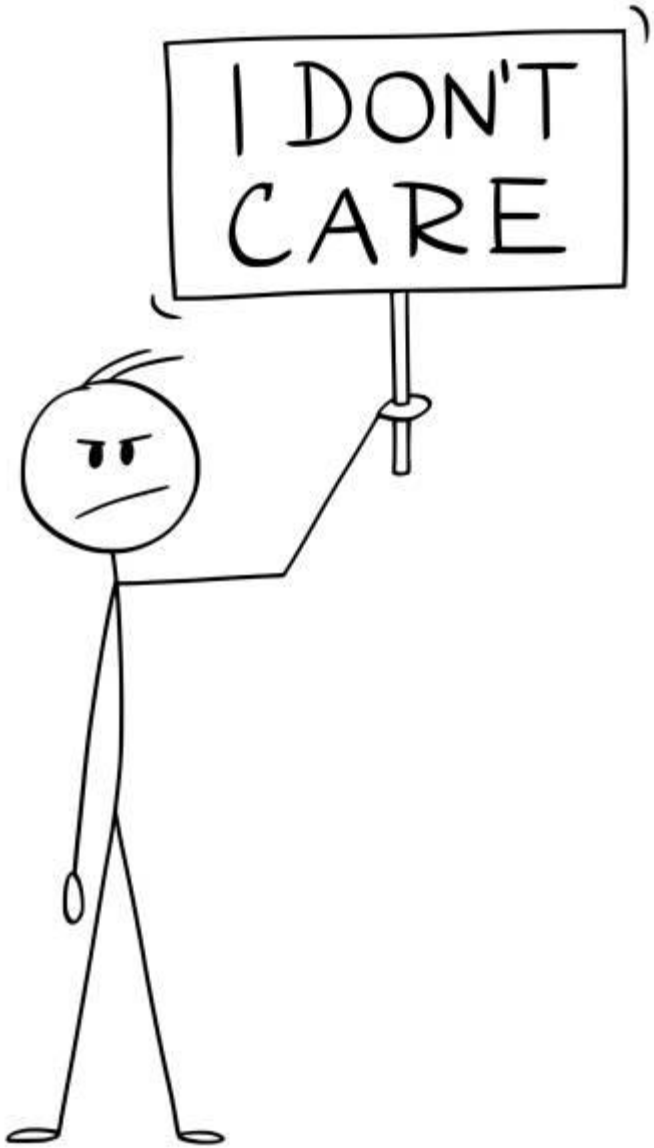
- Expands access to underserved populations.
- May normalize mental health conversations.
- Risk of reinforcing avoidance of human therapy.
- ELIZA effect: illusion of understanding.

# Future Directions

- Hybrid models with clinician supervision.
- Independent auditing and risk-based regulatory frameworks.
- Equity-centered governance to prevent bias.
- Move beyond engagement metrics toward clinical outcomes.

# Conclusion

- AI demonstrates linguistic fluency and scalability.
- Fluency is not understanding.
- Prediction is not care.
- Psychotherapy remains a relational and ethically grounded practice.



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